

Growing Collard Greens in the Piedmont

A cool-season staple of Southern gardens and kitchens

Why Collards

Collards (*Brassica oleracea*) are among the most reliable and culturally important crops in the Southern garden — cold-hardy, productive, and central to soul food traditions. A fall planting can feed a family through winter, and a light frost actually sweetens the leaves.

Planting

- Grow as a fall and winter crop in the Piedmont; also possible in early spring.
- Direct-sow or transplant late summer (Aug–Sept) for fall and winter harvest.
- Space plants 18–24 inches apart in rows; they grow large.
- Full sun and steady moisture produce the most tender leaves.

Care & Common Pests

- Side-dress with nitrogen for steady leaf growth.
- Watch for cabbage worms and aphids; hand-pick or use row cover.
- Harvest outer leaves from the bottom up so the plant keeps producing.
- Plants overwinter in mild Piedmont winters, giving an early-spring second flush.

From Garden to Table

Traditionally cooked slow with smoked meat or in a seasoned pot likker, collards are as much heritage as nutrition. The cooking liquid (pot likker) is prized and nutritious in its own right.